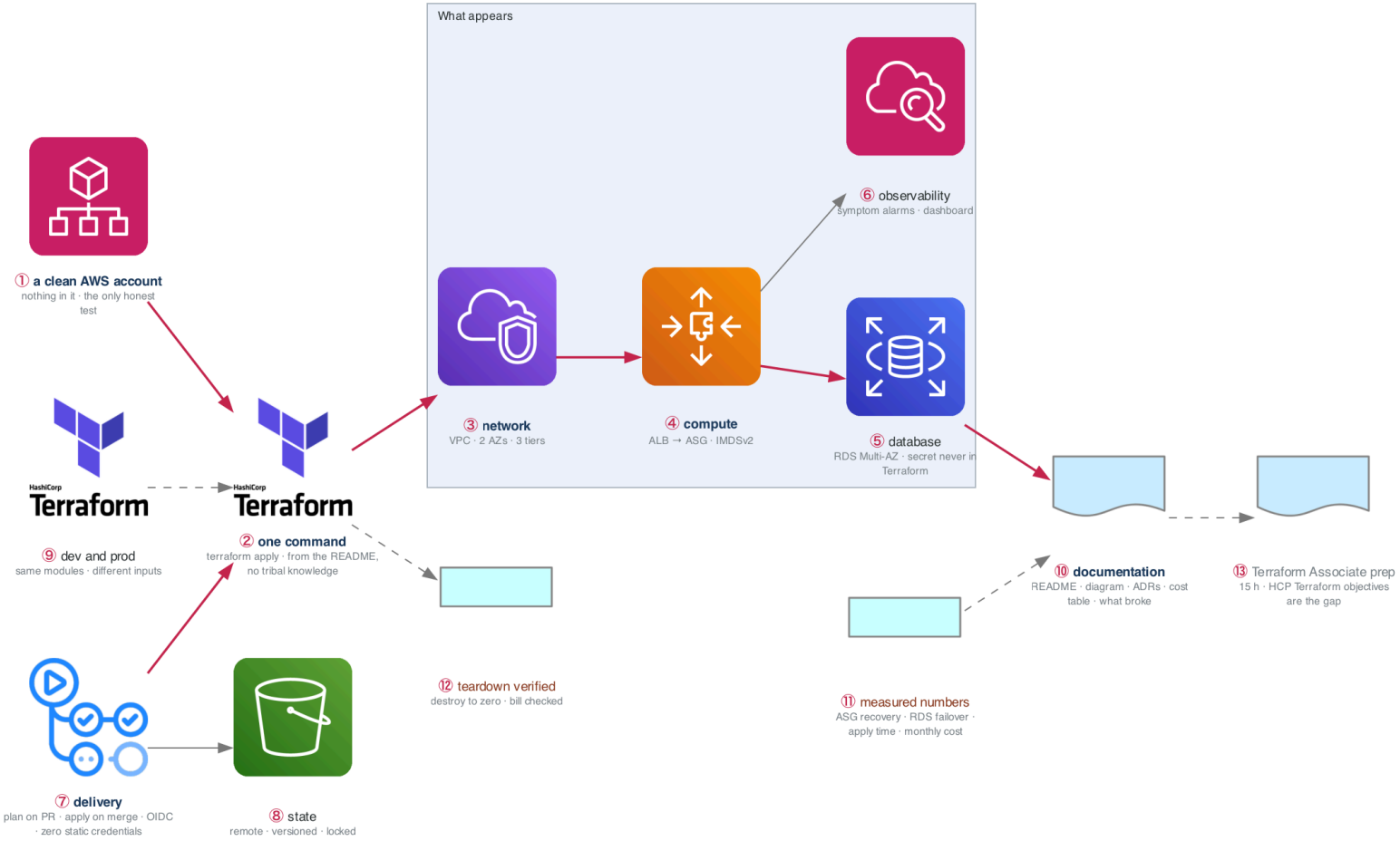
Project Alpha as a reviewer sees it, numbered

Week 13 · Figure 13.1 · figure with badges 1–13 · 2026-10-17



What to say, badge by badge

About three and a half minutes at a normal pace (438 words). Point at each badge as you say its line.

Open
“This is Alpha the way a hiring manager would review it. Not the code, the claims. Every box is a claim the README makes, and Thursday you prove the whole picture in an account that has nothing in it.”

1 **a clean AWS account**
“Ideally a separate account. Otherwise destroy everything, empty the state bucket, and start from nothing. Any leftover resource makes the test a lie.”

2 **one command**
“The README says what to run, and that is all you run. If a step lives only in your head, write it down or automate it. This is the one-command claim, and Gate 3 is checking it literally.”

3 **network**
“The week-6 VPC: two AZs, three tiers, data tier with no route out. Produced by the network module with a CIDR as its only required input.”

4 **compute**
“The week-7 ALB in front of an auto-scaling group, instances on IMDSv2, no SSH port anywhere. Produced by the compute module.”

5 **database**
“RDS Multi-AZ. The password is generated by RDS and stored in Secrets Manager; Terraform never sees the value and it is not in state in the clear.”

6 **observability**
“The module you finish Monday and Tuesday: alarms on symptoms, 5xx rate and latency, not on causes, and a dashboard that shows them. Week 20 goes deeper; this is enough to be honest.”

7 **delivery**
“Plan on every pull request, apply on merge after approval, both through the week-12 OIDC roles. The grep for AKIA returns nothing. That is the single most credible line in the project.”

8 **state**
“Remote in S3, versioned, locked during apply. A reviewer who asks what happens when two people apply at once gets an answer.”

9 **dev and prod**
“Two environments from the same modules with different inputs. Prod has a NAT per AZ and bigger instances; dev has one NAT and small ones. The difference is a variables file.”

10 **documentation**
“A README with the one command, an architecture diagram, ADRs for the decisions you would be asked about, a cost table, and a section called what broke. The last one is read more than any other.”

11 **measured numbers**
“ASG recovery time, RDS failover downtime, how long the apply takes, what a month costs. Your numbers, from Thursday's run. Numbers are what turn a project into a story.”

12 **teardown verified**
“Destroy, then check the bill the next day. A project that costs money after it is done is not done.”

13 **Terraform Associate prep**
“Fifteen hours is enough, and most of it goes to the one domain a self-taught project never touches: HCP Terraform workspaces, VCS-driven runs, remote execution. Book the exam for Monday.”

Close
“One command, a clean account, no credentials, numbers you measured, and a document a stranger can follow. Ship it with three known rough edges rather than polish it into week 16.”